Karl von Eckartshausen — Aufschlüsse zur Magie (1790–1792)

The Boneyard is a collection of works left unfinished, unpublished, or unread at their authors' deaths — dry bones in the valley, in Ezekiel's image. Each presentation tells the scholar's story, weighs what survives of his work, and states plainly what completing it would take, so that a book the world never received whole can be met at last. Each of them was one of one. There will never be another like him, and his light will not shine again except through the work he left behind.

A Boneyard dossier — researched and presented by Robert Tilford, Hays, Kansas. Filed 14 October 2026.

Disclosure: prepared with AI assistance — the subject reviewers are AI agents, each desk-checked at this desk; all rulings and final decisions are the author's own.

Dedication

To Karl von Eckartshausen (1752–1803), the Bavarian Catholic mystic, writer, and philosopher who held that science, magic, and religion belonged together. He is remembered in English chiefly for a short later work, *The Cloud upon the Sanctuary*, which was taken up by occultists, held in high standing in the Hermetic Order of the Golden Dawn, particularly by Arthur Edward Waite, and is known to have attracted Aleister Crowley to that order. His larger work on magic has had no such fortune in English. This presentation is dedicated to the man, and to the four volumes that English readers have never received whole.

The story

Karl von Eckartshausen was born on 28 June 1752 at Haimhausen in Bavaria, and he died on 12 May 1803 at Munich, aged fifty. He studied philosophy and Bavarian civil law in Munich and Ingolstadt. In 1780 he took on the role of secret archivist in Bavaria, work that likely gave him access to much of the knowledge he later gathered into the *Aufschlüsse zur Magie*.

He joined the order of the Illuminati founded by Adam Weishaupt, and withdrew soon afterwards. The record gives his reason plainly: the order, as he

found it, recognised enlightenment through human reason alone, while his own convictions sought knowledge by another road as well. He was acquainted with Johann Georg Schröpfer, an early pioneer of phantasmagoria, and he experimented himself with magic lanterns, creating ghost projections before audiences of four or five people.

His writings were read by contemporaries who included Johann Wolfgang von Goethe, Friedrich Schiller, Nikolai Gogol, and Tsar Alexander I. The work that carried his name furthest was not the one presented here. *Die Wolke über dem Heiligthum* (1802), in English *The Cloud upon the Sanctuary*, is a short work of Christian mysticism centred on an inner church of enlightened souls. Isabelle de Steiger translated it into English, serialised in 1895 and in book form in 1896, with editions introduced by Waite following in 1903 and 1909. That version is in the public domain and available in full on Internet Archive, so the *Wolke* is not an open candidate in this collection. One caution is carried with that closure: no source consulted calls de Steiger's version abridged, but a letter-by-letter collation against the German was not run, so it is described here only as complete-in-form, the bounded form the record supports.

The work and what survives

The stranded work is the larger one. *Aufschlüsse zur Magie aus geprüften Erfahrungen* was published at Munich in four volumes in 1790–1792. Its full title promises insights into magic from tested experience, concerning hidden philosophical sciences and the covered secrets of nature. In the dossier's summary, it treats magic, hidden natural secrets, phantasmagoria, and spirit-apparitions.

In its own account, the secrets of nature reveal themselves only to those who are good of heart, and knowledge so gained is to be used for the betterment of mankind. The book sets out a metaphysical order in which divine light stands at the origin of creation, and it gives practical instructions for creating ghost lanterns, said to have helped popularise phantasmagoria. It also offers explanations for ghostly apparitions, taking a position against Immanuel Kant on whether an optical projection can stand as an analogy for a real spirit appearance.

The German original survives, and the work is in the public domain: the author

died in 1803, and the volumes were published in 1790–1792. What does not survive in English is the work itself, whole.

Its English fortunes

The only English version found is a modern, copyrighted, partial translation: *Magic: The Principles of Higher Knowledge*, published by Merkur at Scarborough, Ontario, in 1989, edited by Gerhard Hanswille and Deborah Brumlich. It is a selection, and four German volumes set against one modern selection leave a genuine gap of the kind this collection exists to record.

The finding is stated at exactly the strength the research supports: **No complete English translation found after research.**

What completing it would take

Completing the work would mean a full English translation of the four German volumes, made from the original text. The work should be staged, with Volume 1 taken as the first unit. The table of contents of the Merkur selection may be used as a reference only, to identify which portions Anglophone readers already have, so that what is still missing can be named plainly, volume by volume.

Sources

- https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Aufschl%C3%BCsse_zur_Magie (the work, its contents, and its phantasmagoria material)
- https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Karl_von_Eckartshausen (life, studies, Illuminati withdrawal, lantern experiments, publication list)
- https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/The_Cloud_upon_the_Sanctuary (the later work and de Steiger's translation)
- https://archive.org/stream/pdfy-9Kt9eHO8qf_V7_E-/The+Cloud+Upon+The+Sanctuary_djvu.txt (public-domain full text of de Steiger's *Cloud*, as pinned in the source dossier)